

Definitions and Scholarly Contextualization

In exploring the world of American defense production, scholarly information is bountiful, yet bound by years of stagnancy. New conflicts and shifting global power dynamics bring new landscapes and perspectives with which the industry can be observed and evaluated from, but the core tenets remain. In attempting to illuminate the current scholarly wisdom on the subject, I am utilizing classical theorists on procurement processes, in combination with those authors who have updated the same tired reporting to fit with modern conflicts. In the following section, I will comprehensively lay out what has been given to us already, and identify the broadening gap within the research.

In order to appropriately introduce the following political and socioeconomic theories, two essential terms must be addressed and contextualized. “Adaption,” or adaptation, is not a term new to the studies of defense procurement; private sector engineers on DoW research and design contracts often receive lengthy specification laundry lists, which are constantly subject to shifting sands leading to a reactionary production pipeline.¹ Not dissimilar in precedence to adaptation, “evolution” is a second crucial term. Nearly every leader of a hegemonic state since the invention of gunpowder has been forced to realize “the evolution and scope of the global arms industry” as a tool for survival.² Yet, despite a well reported interwoven familiarity with these theories, the procurement system remains rigid in nature. In order to understand why, I will explore where and to what capacity the defense industry addresses, utilizes, or neglects adaptations and evolutionary pulls as shaping attributes.

¹ Rosella Cappella Zielinski et al., “American Arms and Industry in a Changing International Order,” *Defence Studies* 24, no. 1 (2024): page 160, 175301692, <https://doi.org/10.1080/14702436.2023.2279624>.

² Lorenzo Scarazzato et al., “Developments in Arms Production and the Effects of the War in Ukraine,” *Defence and Peace Economics* 35, no. 6 (2024): page 675, <https://doi.org/10.1080/10242694.2024.2381784>.

Governments clearly listened when Mark Twain told us that while history doesn't repeat itself, it often rhymes. Scholars have found evidence in the defense realm that “states learn from past experience” when it comes to cyclical improvements in procurement practices.³ Adaptation, in this context, can be considered as a structural change after a shock, or streamlining for speed, rather than building institutions that learn continuously. Learning as a tool for systemic improvements is often retrospective and case-specific, not designed as a standing evolutionary function.

Lessons from Operational Adjustments

21st century scholars are in the process of creating the analytical base for our understanding of reactive shifts in response to the newest major conflict in conversation with the U.S. defense industry: Ukraine. One of the first practical takeaways of the conflict came in late 2023, when essential artillery munitions stockpiles began to run dry. These have long been one of the most hoarded systems by Eastern European powers, and historically subject to huge manufacturing boom/bust cycles preceding and after major conflicts; this would quickly become a major issue if left unaddressed.⁴ What scholars of procurement theory have since realized is that we needed not only to learn from what led to this shortage but with what solutions it was remedied. Allied partners, albeit somewhat gingerly, attempted to help pad existing stockpiles.⁵ When suppliers proved too bureaucratically unstable and marginally untrustworthy, UAVs from smaller, and often domestic producers stepped forward. A point of note from the existing

³ Eoin Lazaridis Power, “The Institutional and Political Determinants of Defense-Industrial Policy” (Ph.D., The University of Texas at Austin, 2025), page 30.
<https://www.proquest.com/docview/3284366764/abstract/2D492DF5662A40EDPQ/5>.

⁴ Jonathan D. Caverley, “Horses, Nails, and Messages: Three Defense Industries of the Ukraine War,” *Contemporary Security Policy* 44, no. 4 (2023): page 613, <https://doi.org/10.1080/13523260.2023.2257965>.

⁵ “U.S. Security Cooperation with Ukraine,” *United States Department of State*, n.d., accessed February 2, 2026, <https://www.state.gov/bureau-of-political-military-affairs/releases/2025/01/u-s-security-cooperation-with-ukraine/>.

literature is that this boom in UAV and FPV adoption was an operational recognition, and a subsequent industry-side supply response.

The shell shortage in 2023 brought most theorists in defense procurement and system manufacturing to a similar central point of contention. How could a shortage in this distinct, large impact weapon system result in the adoption of new battlefield strategies and production pipelines? A common answer to this question brings us to one of the most up to date and contextualized theories on defense manufacturing. The defense industry, while consolidated and hegemonic in nature, cannot be treated as a single political economy. Prime contractors like Lockheed Martin deal in large-scale contracts with 10 year horizons for major force multiplying systems, while artillery shells can come from “diversified companies like Saab and Rheinmetall,” or any number of smaller suppliers within the global supply chain.⁶ This unified framing of the industry, which undeniably seeps into corporate culture and bureaucratic decision making, hides procurement-relevant variation that is essential for nurturing proper production pipelines.

UAV adoption as a study for determining chokepoints in the procurement process has also provided scholars with a better understanding of what being adaptable means in a conflict in the 21st century. A significant amount of research has gone into understanding why and how FPVs (first person view) and OWAs (one way attack) drones have seen such success, and two throughlines connecting the greater conversation seem to be speed and scale. “Affordable mass precision” as an attribute of weapons systems has been indispensable in Ukraine.⁷ This debate has largely been framed by major contributors as a question of “revolutionary” technologies,

⁶ Caverley, “Horses, Nails, and Messages.” page 613.

⁷ Marcel Plichta and Ash Rossiter, “A One-Way Attack Drone Revolution? Affordable Mass Precision in Modern Conflict,” *Journal of Strategic Studies* 47, nos. 6–7 (2024): page 1006, <https://doi.org/10.1080/01402390.2024.2385843>.

however, this holds a tight framing of a by-conflict basis, rather than exploring the nature of drone adaptation as a whole.^{8 9}

Contributing to the question of revolutionary or not, some have expanded their persuasion to encompass the attributes of drones beyond just operational capacity. Ease of procurement, particularly that of dual-use drones, is often highlighted. Companies such as DJI and Parrot, known for their high civilian consumer base, were co-opted early in the conflict due to their usability and ease of access.^{10 11} However, while the ease of access did provide a guerilla style “democratization of air power” through dual-use technologies, it brought scale issues down the line.¹² Low-cost drone proliferation drives parallel requirements on the procurement side, as the speed of adoption and field deployment necessitates a matching acquisition process. Reforms built for such systems struggle when the advantage comes from iteration and volume.

The largest existing lesson I will present from Ukraine is one that is extremely tethered and conflict-specific. Drone warfare, an unconventional form of conflict, has been backed by an equally unconventional supply chain not applicable to current U.S. processes. Our current systems are optimized for compliance and predictability, which does not require an ecosystem optimized for speed and iteration. Ukrainian supply chains are near polar opposites. Civil producers have gained a huge foothold, largely through grassroots strategies forged out of a state

⁸ Plichta and Rossiter, “A One-Way Attack Drone Revolution?” page 1020.

⁹ While their debate remains technologically focused, Plichta and Rossiter emphasize autonomy as a determining factor for “revolutionary” military evolutions. Autonomy within weapons systems is likely to go hand-in-hand with greater bureaucratic and private industry culture shifts I will argue for later on. My focus remains on holistic review and abstaining from temporal analysis, but companies focused on producing autonomous systems, such as Anduril and ShieldAI, tend to share the production ideals I envision in a revised procurement system; these actors are among the only ones currently pushing for adaptive, evolutionary change within the defense industry. See pages 7 and 8 for more.

¹⁰ Sungwon Lee et al., “Digital Forensic Research for Analyzing Drone Pilot: Focusing on DJI Remote Controller,” *Sensors* 23, no. 21 (2023): page 2, <https://doi.org/10.3390/s23218934>.

¹¹ Leo Chiu, “Ukraine to Mass-Produce Homegrown Mavic Drone Alternatives, Zelensky Says,” *Kyiv Post*, November 7, 2025, <https://www.kyivpost.com/post/63864>.

¹² Anik Mondal, “Low Cost Drones in Modern Warfare and Counter Drone Strategies: A Review,” *International Journal for Research in Applied Science and Engineering Technology* 13, no. 6 (2025): page 2328, <https://doi.org/10.22214/ijraset.2025.72632>.

in wartime. With this environment, defense producers not only have the option to perform core “functions of sovereignty outside the formal sovereign apparatus,” but explicitly benefit the state by exercising this option.¹³ By expanding beyond traditional pipelines and into the socio-military ether of a wartime society, issues stemming from supply chains, bureaucratic red tape, and conglomerate stagnancy associated with large primes can be side stepped.¹⁴ This speed and focus on applied iteration has proven adaptable and battle tested throughout the conflict.

Predictive Optimization and Foresight

Our government, despite what the noise and clamor of news cycles may suggest, is often planning for situations that will not come to fruition until years down the line. This goes doubly for the defense industry, as strategic spending priorities for the military are often decided based on wargames centered around extremely distant clashes. The result of this system, some have noticed, is an industry built for niche optimization. Many look to post Cold-War industrial tendencies as a signifier of this trend. Using lessons from the conflict and bold assumptions about future ones, U.S. lawmakers centered their focus on “boost[ing] growth through greater efficiency, consolidation, and private-sector investment” within the defense industrial complex.¹⁵

¹⁶ The rationale of this decision was— and remains today— extremely clear. What scholars with hindsight have now noticed is it was a time-bound rationality, of which rigid supply chain and

¹³ Kateryna Zarembo and Raluca Csernaton, “Civil Society as Arms Producer: Oxymoron or Reality?: Ukraine’s Drone Production in Response to the Russian Invasion,” *Journal of Political & Military Sociology* 51, no. 2 (2025), page 221. <https://doi.org/10.5744/jpms.2024.2004>.

¹⁴ A civil producer ecosystem, despite showing high efficacy in Ukraine, still has its own set of issues that cannot be ignored. Namely, mentioned by Zarembo and Csernaton, are the issues of funding and lack of experienced dual public-private corporate leaders. In this sense this system is quite tailored to Ukraine, and its strengths are meant to contrast to that of the U.S.’s without ignoring its own weaknesses.

¹⁵ Cappella Zielinski et al., “American Arms and Industry in a Changing International Order,” page 161.

¹⁶ “Bold assumptions” regarding future conflicts is not meant to be derogatory here. Rather, it is the way with which our military and governmental officials utilize these wargamed scenarios to plan for future defense buildup that I wish to comment on.

manufacturing standards were set. Here I tightly follow what scholars Cappella Zielinski et al. determined throughout their research, as the following 3 attributes strongly supported the defense industrial theory of the time, and have since contributed to a largely unadaptable procurement system. Firstly, “lower labor costs led to increased distribution of production chains,” leading to “increased industry profits even as defense spending fell as a percentage of GDP.”¹⁷ Secondly, the “control of strategic technologies,” or simply nascent systems lending themselves to DoW ““spin-off” technologies,” was pushed to commercial tech giants.¹⁸ Finally, our budgetary system which is bogged down by long, cyclical approval horizons “encourages stability at the expense of flexibility and capacity.”¹⁹

The attributes that elevated the defense industry in many ways during the post Cold War shift, namely financial growth for the primes, have since proved temporal in nature and a lackluster structure for ongoing procurement needs. The issue here has been identified as a reliance on prime contractors, resulting from over-consolidation.²⁰ For years, “the [DoW] only had one supplier,” and the corresponding supply chain options for the DoW’s acquisition conduits were just as strict.²¹ The resulting system from this era, while maintaining a plethora of strengths that cannot be ignored, led to a slide towards lock-in for the greater procurement culture. This is in large part due to a dependency born out of process/pipeline tightening within the defense industry, and that dependency in turn contributed to a system less capable of evolutionary switching.

¹⁷ Cappella Zielinski et al., “American Arms and Industry in a Changing International Order,” page 161.

¹⁸ *ibid.*

¹⁹ *ibid.*

²⁰ Prime contractors do not inherently create an environment where the DoW’s strategic focuses fail to flourish. These companies are very good at accomplishing what they are asked and expected to do, but their scope remains predetermined and subject to the pace and direction of bureaucratic reforms within procurement cycles.

²¹ Cappella Zielinski et al., “American Arms and Industry in a Changing International Order,” page 161.

The reforms resulting from this era, both successful at what they aimed to achieve and flawed by the revelations brought in time, were not simply the easiest fix of the time. As with any governmental upgrades, whether they be a quick fix or a structural shift, are time and energy intensive. The peculiarities of the defense industry in particular make “adjusting the size, shape, and goals of the U.S. defense procurement effort...a difficult political challenge.”²² The “why” of this phenomenon of course changes with the era, and during this particular reform cycle, many acknowledged the “pork barrel politics” correlating to high industry-side incentive for “investing in politics.”²³ While lobbying is as integral and intertwined to D.C. as the metro, the role it plays for defense was born out of necessity.²⁴ For defense, what was once a band-aid for spending lags after the Cold War, is now an engrained part of the procurement process.

Industry-Side Reactionary Shifts

Previously, I touched on Ukraine as an analytical stomping ground for researchers looking at operational epiphanies. While scholars were able to study industry reactions to said realizations, the theories were tethered and conflict specific. However, other literature has given us insight into more general distinctions between battlefield learning and industrial responsiveness that is far less conflict-specific. To generalize more from the Ukrainian case for now, “combat units [modifying] their tactics” is not uncommon in war; in Ukraine, the civil-society defense producers allowed manufacturers to change their tactics in tandem with

²² Eugene Gholz and Harvey M. Sapolsky, “Restructuring the U.S. Defense Industry,” *International Security* 24, no. 3 (1999): page 6.

²³ Gholz and Sapolsky, “Restructuring the U.S. Defense Industry,” pages 17 & 22.

²⁴ Lobbying as a tool is not distinct to defense, nor did the defense industry adopt it only after the Cold War ended. Rather, the biggest lobbies both in terms of capital and registered lobbyists tend to be pharmaceuticals and miscellaneous electronics companies. This example is meant to display the adoption/integration of a procurement mechanism that remains in strength today.

soldiers.²⁵ Classifying these changes as “expedients,” scholars in conflict cite these as necessary battlefield adoptions.²⁶ However, expedients seem to be an unacknowledged part of design and iteration pipelines in defense pipelines. To meet evolving requirements in the field, producers would rather develop a new rifle than disseminate modifying components to existing models.²⁷ The lack of communicative power between these two groups is conducive to poor programming, as evidenced by numerous projects with limited operational deployment success. This nonetheless brings up another issue. Even if expedients were acknowledged and acted upon on the industry-side, it is unlikely that the procurement system would be complimentary enough to effectively integrate it into production.

The issue of communication and system failures in relation to expedient adaptations does occasionally fix itself, particularly when major shocks occur that force the government's bureaucratic hand. Realizations leading to this often come in the form of major shocks, or simply enough of either communicative failure or systemic lag that flaws slowly become too large to ignore. The resulting shock, so to speak, is often a boiling over of obvious gaps in strategic reasoning that have been put off too long to be ignored. Technological and organizational shifts, whether towards the end of major conflicts or absurdly after the fact, create discontinuities that force institutional change, but bureaucracies respond imperfectly and often belatedly.²⁸ This is one of the major cycles recognized by the literature, wherein the lag between battlefields,

²⁵ Marc R. DeVore, “Armaments after Autonomy: Military Adaptation and the Drive for Domestic Defence Industries,” *Journal of Strategic Studies* 44, no. 3 (2021): page 47, <https://doi.org/10.1080/01402390.2019.1612377>.

²⁶ DeVore, “Armaments after Autonomy,” page 27.

²⁷ The U.S. Army recently made the decision to sunset the M4 carbine family, and produce a new rifle dubbed the XM5/XM250 (under contract with SIG Sauer). Despite servicemembers citing the M4's high performance under stress, and the ability to fix common issues such as feeding by using different ammunition types and magazines, the decision went through. The 2022 contract has a 10 year horizon, and is estimated to reach up to \$4.5 billion. Best estimates on total M4 spending currently is close to \$400–\$600 million all in.

²⁸ Eliot A. Cohen, “A Revolution in Warfare,” *Foreign Affairs* 75, no. 2 (1996): page 38, <https://doi.org/10.2307/20047487>.

Congress, board rooms, factories, and eventually battlefields again is delayed enough to make any revolutionary technological advancements moot.

This lag is a hard one to contend with when scholars compare defense firms to the greater technological industry. The Silicon Valley collective has nearly perfected the art of rapid ideation and production; the rise of AI through companies like OpenAI and Anthropic was followed incredibly quickly by hundreds of adoptive technologies expanding the use case and possibilities of what we thought was possible.²⁹ Christian Brose, once the National Security Advisor to Senator John McCain and now the President and Chief Strategy Officer at Anduril Industries, brings some of the most current and informed advocacy to this subject. As a member of the growing community of Silicon Valley-style defense technology companies, he has cited their ability to match tech firms in their capacity to advance on continuous update cycles. However, the section of the defense industry that may very well be moving in the right direction internally, nonetheless remains bound to multiyear hardware-centric acquisition timelines, producing persistent technological lag and military systems whose software updates are locked to hardware refresh cycles.³⁰ The resulting cycle includes one major defined outcome: “debates on the future of war often suffer from being technologically sanitized,” due to an expectation of lag and the neutering of any potential benefits stemming from technological foresight.³¹ This heavily decreases incentive and efficacy for the type of companies Brose elevates, as U.S. procurement adapts episodically adding people, programs, or exceptions, rather than evolving into a system designed for continuous technological absorption.

²⁹ Christian Brose, *The Kill Chain* (2020; Grand Central Publishing, 2019), page 58, <https://www.hachettebookgroup.com/titles/christian-brose/the-kill-chain/9780316533362/?lens=grand-central-publishing>.

³⁰ Brose, *The Kill Chain*, page 61.

³¹ Warren Chin, “Technology, War and the State: Past, Present and Future,” *International Affairs* (Royal Institute of International Affairs 1944-) 95, no. 4 (2019): page 772.

Reformatory Attempts

Some of the sharpest critiques of the procurement system do in fact attempt to address the reform process and its failures. 20/20 vision has given scholars an understanding that reform requires a complex comprehensiveness, an understandable demand for an institution built up over a couple centuries with nooks and crannies even seasoned policy makers do not always understand fully. Eide shows us that large changes are possible, but where these often fail is their ability to either achieve trickle down effects or proper alignment with other structural dependencies.³² Two examples are the 1994 “Perry Memo” and 1997 “Defense Reform Initiative,” which shifted requirements on the type of language used on the bureaucratic-side to more closely align with private-side design and production specifications. While good reforms, this change may have actually contributed to the long delivery horizons we see today, as it led to similar communication issues I previously outlined.³³ I have covered literature that specifies shock as a leading cause of reform, but additionally, others have found that acquisition reform seems to repeatedly reappear because underlying incentives and culture persist even as aspects of the structure change.

An important point to establish in the way that scholars look at tangible reform, as Shaffer & Snider illustrate, is that research remains fragmented and practitioner-oriented, with little cumulative theory-building despite decades of reform efforts.³⁴ Seeing as scholarship overwhelmingly focuses on applied, problem-solving fixes (including but not limited to contracting, logistics, and cost/schedule control) rather than foundational or theoretical questions about how acquisition systems should evolve over time, the field lacks an organizing theoretical

³² Peter K. Eide, *The More Things Change, Acquisition Reform Remains the Same*: (Defense Technical Information Center, 2011), pages 5 & 6, <https://doi.org/10.21236/ADA560205>.

³³ See pages 7 and 8 for a refresher on top-down communication failures and their relation to defense production.

³⁴ Karey L. Shaffer and Keith F. Snider, “Seven Years of U.S. Defense Acquisition Research: Analysis of Proposals and Projects,” *Journal of Public Procurement* 14, no. 4 (2014): page 461, <https://doi.org/10.1108/JOPP-14-04-2014-B001>.

core. Some have noticed that this temporal, hyper specific way with which others digest the subject has caused a pattern of overlooking budget issues as a variable in procurement.³⁵ Continuously failing to consider such an integral part of the acquisition process is indicative of the field of study as a whole. Unquestionably, this leaves acquisition reform as a reactive and episodic body rather than cumulative or evolutionary.

Measuring What Works

In my analysis of major scholarly works, I have described many theories as “temporal,” or momentary fixes. However, under America’s current administration, defense reforms have seen a new cycle take form and scholars have gotten the opportunity to perform live research on Other Transactions Authorities (OTAs).³⁶ This system, which has been a part of the DoW ecosystem since 1989, may not have proved as temporal as other reforms, yet, still remains an imperfect bandaid despite this. It has, at times, been extremely favored by lawmakers and industry alike. In practice, it helps bypass the “vast majority of existing laws and regulations dictating how the government goes about spending money,” including much of the Federal Acquisition Regulation framework.³⁷ By side-stepping much of the traditional procurement pipeline, this backdoor can enable rapid, flexible prototype agreements. However, this system sits on top of an existing infrastructure which, beyond the fact that it requires bypassing to begin with, makes it extremely difficult to do so. OTAs are widely agreed to be retrofitted for innovation and speed, but what experts have been noticing is that this acts as more of an escape

³⁵ J. Ronald (John Ronald) Fox et al., *Defense Acquisition Reform 1960-2009: An Elusive Goal*, CMH Pub ; pages 88-95 (Defense Department, 2011), <https://purl.fdlp.gov/GPO/gpo27025>.

³⁶ From here on out I will use the term OTA interchangeably with Production OTAs (P-OTAs). OTAs are generally meant for research prototyping, whereas P-OTAs extend into scaled production agreements without formal traditional production contracts.

³⁷ William J. Weinig, “OTHER TRANSACTION AUTHORITY: Saint or Sinner For DEFENSE ACQUISITION?,” *Defense Acquisition Research Journal: A Publication of the Defense Acquisition University* 26, no. 2 (2019): page 109, 136595301, <https://doi.org/10.22594/dau.19-818.26.02>.

hatch than anything else. Rather than redesigning an institution to be adaptable by default, a path outside the traditional channel must be created and utilized to achieve results, muddying the entire process and adding more convoluted layers to the procurement pipeline.

When describing OTAs as an escape hatch, or even a bandaid on an existing system, they have the tendency to sound like fearmongering or illegitimate. What makes this process so distinctly flawed—without even putting it in the context of 250-odd years of existing defense acquisition reform cycles—is the same complex legalese that it derives its efficacy from. OTAs are not, and henceforth do not operate as contracts with the government. Because of this OTAs “generally are exempt from the statutes and regulations pertaining to contracts, grants, and cooperative agreements” that bog down the procurement process with legislative and bureaucratic red tape.³⁸ However, the very flexibility that fosters attractiveness to the pipeline also creates ambiguity in coverage gaps where OTAs can slip through, creating separation from important governing statutes of the traditional procurement pipeline.³⁹ This specific system found success by inhabiting a part of procurement distinct from the main institution, but that act in itself created a whole new set of issues. Rather than adapting the acquisition system to have a similar positive outcome in terms of speed and innovation, OTAs in effect created a whole new set of issues that will eventually face major reforms.

The specific attributes of OTAs, what some consider a strength and others a weakness, nonetheless can have a positive outcome when utilized properly. These positive aspects are of note, as while the system itself is not adaptable, it contains strengths that are highly adaptable

³⁸ Nikole R. Snyder, “Jurisdiction Over Federal Procurement Disputes: The Puzzle of Other Transaction Agreements,” *Public Contract Law Journal* 48, no. 3 (2019): page 520.

³⁹ Snyder mentions a plethora of ways with which OTAs are able to sit in a space of legal limbo. Most convincingly, is the lack of compliance with the doctrine of sovereign immunity, which allows the “government to remain immune from [a] suit without its express permission.” While “several statutes act as waivers of sovereign immunity” for procurement contracts, if a party wishes to bring an OTA related suit against the federal government, sovereign immunity would be a major legal barrier to overcome. See Snyder pages 523-524.

within the vacuum of OTA usage. Scholars who view it as a transformative system with far-reaching implications for the future of procurement tend to highlight its flexibility as a key trait.⁴⁰ This flexibility comes in a few varieties, with distinctly different outcomes contributing to its efficacy. Firstly, the payment structure and deal outline tend to resemble that of a commercial agreement, lowering the barrier to entry for some companies. Whereas larger primes have whole departments trained on DoW language and contracting, smaller firms, with less manpower and experience, rely on OTAs for securing business. Additionally, the decreased restrictions on specification and capability standards for weapons systems mean design and production pipelines are tightened. While getting paid a couple years sooner seems insignificant for companies charging millions of dollars per delivery, smaller Silicon Valley style companies often tend to favor innovation over stability and can't afford to wait as long as prime contractors.⁴¹ These factors allow OTAs to create tailored deals that not only benefit, but incentivize the private sector to collaborate with the government to achieve mutually agreeable outcomes. Many researchers have dubbed OTAs as a win-win in terms of private-public partnership within the defense industry, yet this system still sits outside of the proper procurement channels, and still remains a temporary, strained, fix for a broken system.

Bureaucratic Failures

Mentions of reformatory failures often, as I have displayed, concern the “what,” usually leading to scholarly discussion of systemic misalignment or some other major structural issue. This is because the institution of acquisitions is so large that to even identify what the reform

⁴⁰ Douglas Steinberg, “Leveraging the Department of Defense’s Other Transaction Authority TO FOSTER A TWENTY-FIRST CENTURY ACQUISITION ECOSYSTEM,” *Public Contract Law Journal* 49, no. 3 (2020): page 557.

⁴¹ Steinberg, “Leveraging the Department of Defense’s Other Transaction Authority TO FOSTER A TWENTY-FIRST CENTURY ACQUISITION ECOSYSTEM,” page 551.

issue is, let alone why it's an issue, takes deep research and analysis. However, when taken a step further, the “how” and “why” helps us gain a comprehensive understanding of these issues. Some have argued that these reforms fail systemically because they lack the penetrative power to actually shift the mechanisms that make or break success in procurement. Changing processes that have no tangible effect on the end result can masquerade as changing the behavior of the system, but in effect produces the same output.⁴² To create shifts that affect the system positively, reforms have to target the areas of procurement that contribute to rigidly and lackluster processing speeds.

Rigid systems also are not always identifiable as rigid to all parties involved; a set of normative standards that may seem perfect by the government’s requirements are interpreted far differently by the variety of contractors encouraged to work with them. Reforms often target the known entities of contracting, such as prior experience with the prime contractors. When bureaucratic efforts still manage to misunderstand the larger contractors requests, they will likely completely forget those of the smaller contractors. As a nascent part of the equation, it becomes “near impossible for small businesses” to navigate reforms misaligned with the reality of their industry.⁴³ This misalignment can then reinforce existing market hierarchies, as firms without the institutional familiarity or compliance infrastructure of established primes are effectively screened out before meaningful participation can occur. In attempting to reform the system without altering its underlying cultural and procedural rigidity, policymakers inadvertently preserve the very barriers that prevent new entrants from strengthening the industrial base.

Reforms tend to take shape by applying lessons of the past to assumptions of the future, an equation which churns out legislation and requirements usually lacking in transformative

⁴² Eide, *The More Things Change, Acquisition Reform Remains the Same*, page 17.

⁴³ Bill Shuster et al., *PANEL ON BUSINESS CHALLENGES WITHIN THE DEFENSE INDUSTRY*, n.d, page 38.

substance and in effect protects the status quo. Scholars have picked up on this lag, noticing for example, that “the quantitative and qualitative analysis of the arms trade is largely the study of fighter aircraft...while important weapons, aircraft, much less ships, have not been the war’s pivotal weapon.”⁴⁴ Focusing on systems most prominent in recent conflicts creates a system of expectations and correlated requirements, which may not necessarily be suited for the wars to come. This procurement track enables the continuation of what has worked well in the past, but removes the opportunity for adaptation acquisition should the need arise.

9) Oversight, crisis narratives, and why reform is always “after the fact”

Paragraph 27 — Oversight reports as snapshots: reform framed as catching up

Synopsis: Use Comer’s oversight framing to show policymakers themselves narrate procurement as too slow for modern iteration.

- Quote (use directly if you’re pulling it in your final draft): the report contrasts Ukraine’s rapid drone iteration with U.S.-style timelines (Comer, p.1–2).
- Use this as evidence that reform discourse is reactive—aimed at catching up to the current war’s lesson.

Paragraph 28 — Why today’s reform menu still implies tomorrow’s reform need

Synopsis: Synthesize: OTAs, PPBE tweaks, industrial base investments, competition initiatives—each is framed as a fix for current strategic conditions (China pacing threat, Ukraine consumption rates, tech acceleration).

⁴⁴ Caverley, “Horses, Nails, and Messages,” page 611.

- Pull in your strongest “time-bound optimization” line again (Cappella Zielinski, p.1) and your strongest “discipline missed it” line (Caverley, p.3).
- Argue: these reforms are *necessary* but not *self-renewing*; they don’t embed a permanent evolutionary function.

10) Conclusion: the research gap you will claim

Paragraph 29 — Your gap: from “adaptation to the time” to “adaptability as design”

Synopsis: State the gap precisely: the literature diagnoses rigidity and proposes reforms tied to specific periods (post–Cold War drawdown, COIN era, Ukraine/China era), but does not fully specify the cultural, bureaucratic, and systemic redesign needed to make procurement continuously adaptive—reducing the need for future major shifts.

- Use: recurring reform cycle logic (Eide, p.1–4; Shaffer, p.452).
- Use: wartime demand/tempo pressure (Caverley, p.3; Cappella Zielinski, p.2).
- Use: “escape hatch” critique (Weinig, p.1; Snyder, p.1; Steinberg, p.2–3).
- End with your forward pointer: your thesis will propose the specific cultural norms, bureaucratic incentives, and institutional structures that would embed “adaptability and evolutionary resilience” as standing features—rather than crisis responses.